

Copter rovers?

Since driving on Mars is difficult, NASA's working on mini rover copters that can fly to provide a better view. <http://dgit.in/CopterRover>



Samsung Apple BFFs

Recent reports indicate that Samsung-made SoCs will power the next generation of Apple's iPhone. http://dgit.in/App_Sung

incremental and there's not much new to sell a device on. Enter selfies. The front camera, which used to be nothing more than a number on the specification sheet has suddenly taken centre stage, becoming big, both literally and figuratively. It has become an important marketing weapon for companies to pitch their smartphones to a selfie-obsessed public.

Login to Facebook and your news feed is flooded with people making faces that ducks never would, but there's no shame. Selfies are a thing. Meet a celebrity and you no longer ask for a picture with them, you ask for a selfie. Or maybe you've met your old friends after a long time, what

do you do? Yes, of course, it's time for a 'groupie'.

Just like the term 'phablet' was once coined in order to explain big screen phones, the term 'selfie' has been devised, as a way to sell more phones. And why not?

It's not wrong either, after all, why shouldn't the front camera be important. Why should it remain a gimmick, when it can be put to more use? The smartphone camera has all but replaced traditional cameras today, so why should the two cameras together not deal the final blow to point-n-shoot cameras? Well, it's happening as we speak. Selfies are only the beginning and it's only a matter of time till people

realise that it can be put to a lot of use.

For example, a good front facing camera can be a great tool for those who make their own podcasts. It can also be a very good tool for making video resumes. The applications will come up with time.

With all that said, it is evident that the front camera, or the 'selfie' camera as many call it, is a very important part of a phone's specification list right now, which means, it is an opportune time to compare these phones based on that. So, as we've done often in the past, we went ahead and called up the companies that make these devices. We told them we were doing this shootout

and would be needing the best that they could offer. Seven of them obliged.

The result is as follows.

Lava Iris X5

Beginning with the cheapest device amongst the lot, the Lava Iris X5 is amongst the cheapest selfie smartphones available today. It has a 5MP front camera, with a BSI sensor and an f/2.2 aperture. Other specs include a 1.2 Ghz quad-core processor, 1GB of RAM, a 5 inch HD display and an 8MP rear camera.

The Iris X5 actually started out very well, with images taken under optimal light conditions, that is, outdoor sunlight. Images taken were

HOW WE TESTED

Right at the offset, let's make it clear that this comparison was based on the front camera performance of the smartphones used. 70 per cent of the weightage was given to the front camera performance and other aspects that affect it, the other 30 per cent went to other features. More on that in a minute.

So as we were saying, we told the companies we needed their devices for a selfie shootout. It was up to them to decide which phone they would want competing. We received the HTC Desire Eye, Sony Xperia C3, Nokia (Microsoft) Lumia 730, Oppo N1 Mini, Gionee Elife E7, Lava Iris X5 and the Moto X (2nd Gen). Yes, that last one confused us too, but that too shall be explained later.

As mentioned above, this test was predominantly about the front camera, so we took into consideration the image quality, including things like the sharpness of the image, colour reproduction, white balance etc. All this was tested in indoor lighting conditions (fluorescent or tubelights), outdoor sunlight and low light conditions.

We also took into consideration the various selfie apps that OEMs put into their devices today, marking them for ease of use, number of features and how much control they give

you over the finished product that you will get from the camera.

Next came features like voice controlled selfies or other equivalent features, which would make it easier to take a selfie. Voice control over the front camera for example, would ensure that your device doesn't move when you're trying to press the on-screen shutter button. The same is achieved, albeit to a lesser degree, when a separate camera shutter button is present on the phone. Alternatively, a phone may even have features where it automatically recognises when to take a selfie. All this was rated with respect to how effective they were and how easy or difficult it made to take a selfie.

We also considered camera placement, with a centre position being the best for framing your image. The sensor type was also taken into consideration, since BSI sensors offer better low light photos than others.

Finally, 30 per cent of the ratings were based on the CPU Speed, number of cores, RAM and other features of the devices. These features can affect how fast you can open the camera app when you need it, the processing time once the image has been clicked etc. Some marks were also given for the amount

of storage that the devices had and whether they supported Cloud Storage or offered extra cloud storage, over and above what Google gives you anyway.

With all that said, there was only one element left to consider, that being the price. As you may have already noted, the phones mentioned above range from under ₹10,000 to above ₹30,000, which means they should ideally not be competing against each other. But, that doesn't matter, since the aim of this comparison is to establish the best selfie smartphone today, followed by the best buy.

So, the best performer is the one that can take the best images using the front camera, meant for those who have no budget concerns and simply want the best. The best buy on the other hand takes very good selfies, while also being affordable and providing good value for money. There will also be an editor's pick, for the phone that came close, but couldn't make it to the top in the self-obsessed selfie race.

Due to the difference in pricing, we'll be taking up each of the smartphones in the comparison and explaining their pros and cons individually, including why they could or could not make it to the top of the charts in this test.

Let's begin.